ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · May 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Raleigh	80.7
#2	A+	Atlanta	74.9
#3	A+	Austin	73.1
#4	A+	Kansas City	68.7
#5	A	Cincinnati	66.8
#6	A	Nashville	66.8
#7	A	Hartford	65.4

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Jacksonville	22.6
#49	C-	Louisville	29.8
#48	C-	Riverside	31.1
#47	C-	Portland	31.7
#46	C	Richmond	33.0
#45	C	Minneapolis	33.1
#44	C	Philadelphia	33.1

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	11 cities
B+ / B / B-	22 cities
C+ / C / C-	16 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · May 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	**Raleigh** Raleigh-Cary	A+	80.7	3.0%	+4.3%	+2.0%	+1.7%	44 days
2	**Atlanta** Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	A+	74.9	3.3%	+5.2%	+0.4%	+1.4%	49 days
3	**Austin** Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A+	73.1	3.4%	+7.8%	+1.1%	+0.8%	51 days
4	**Kansas City** Kansas City	A+	68.7	3.9%	+7.0%	+0.0%	+0.4%	41 days
5	**Cincinnati** Cincinnati	A	66.8	3.7%	+3.3%	+0.1%	-0.4%	37 days
6	**Nashville** Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A	66.8	2.9%	+3.9%	+0.8%	-0.4%	50 days
7	**Hartford** Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A	65.4	2.7%	+0.6%	+1.9%	+2.8%	25 days
8	**Dallas** Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	A	63.9	3.9%	+3.1%	+0.9%	+0.5%	46 days
9	**Birmingham** Birmingham	A-	61.0	2.7%	-0.9%	+0.7%	+0.3%	52 days
10	**San Jose** San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	A-	60.3	3.9%	+0.8%	+1.6%	-0.1%	28 days
11	**Las Vegas** Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	A-	60.2	5.4%	+6.2%	+1.5%	+2.4%	51 days
12	**Charlotte** Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	B+	59.0	3.7%	-0.0%	+0.9%	+1.1%	45 days
13	**Pittsburgh** Pittsburgh	B+	58.5	4.0%	+6.4%	-0.6%	+1.2%	50 days
14	**Salt Lake City** Salt Lake City-Murray	B+	58.5	3.9%	+4.9%	+1.1%	-0.7%	44 days
15	**San Diego** San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B+	56.6	4.3%	+5.9%	+1.0%	-0.7%	38 days
16	**Columbus** Columbus	B+	55.4	3.4%	+2.8%	+0.5%	-0.3%	36 days
17	**Los Angeles** Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B	54.2	4.8%	+5.2%	+1.8%	-0.5%	46 days
18	**Seattle** Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	50.7	4.9%	+8.1%	-0.1%	-0.8%	34 days
19	**San Francisco** San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B	50.5	4.0%	+6.2%	+0.2%	-1.4%	31 days
20	**Oklahoma City** Oklahoma City	B	50.1	3.4%	+6.8%	-0.9%	-1.2%	51 days
21	**Memphis** Memphis	B-	49.9	4.2%	+5.0%	-0.0%	-0.8%	54 days
22	**Houston** Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B-	49.4	4.4%	+2.0%	+0.5%	+0.3%	48 days
23	**Miami** Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	48.4	3.7%	+8.0%	-0.6%	+0.1%	77 days
24	**Cleveland** Cleveland	B-	48.4	3.4%	-0.2%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	**Providence** Providence-Warwick	B-	48.4	4.3%	+3.8%	+0.6%	+1.7%	27 days
26	**Grand Rapids** Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	B-	47.8	4.0%	+3.8%	-0.1%	-4.5%	37 days
27	**Orlando** Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B-	46.7	4.4%	+1.6%	+0.8%	+1.1%	68 days
28	**Tampa** Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	46.0	4.5%	+7.8%	-0.3%	+0.1%	67 days
29	**Denver** Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	46.0	3.7%	+1.6%	-0.4%	-2.3%	39 days
30	**San Antonio** San Antonio-New Braunfels	B-	45.3	4.0%	+3.0%	+0.3%	-0.2%	53 days
31	**Chicago** Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	B-	44.8	5.1%	+4.2%	-0.1%	-0.9%	34 days
32	**New York** New York Newark-Jersey City	B-	44.6	4.5%	+6.1%	-0.6%	+0.7%	41 days
33	**Virginia Beach** Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	B-	44.6	3.9%	+7.5%	-0.7%	-0.4%	35 days
34	**Fresno** Fresno	C+	44.0	8.9%	+4.4%	+2.1%	-0.2%	50 days
35	**Indianapolis** Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C+	43.3	3.3%	+0.6%	-0.5%	-0.5%	41 days
36	**Phoenix** Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	C+	40.0	4.0%	+3.7%	-0.2%	-1.0%	57 days
37	**St. Louis** St. Louis	C+	39.2	4.3%	+0.6%	-0.6%	+0.4%	42 days
38	**Baltimore** Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C+	39.1	4.3%	+5.3%	-1.4%	+0.8%	32 days
39	**Detroit** Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C	35.6	5.3%	+2.0%	-0.4%	+0.9%	39 days
40	**Milwaukee** Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	35.6	4.2%	+2.8%	-0.8%	-0.0%	36 days
41	**Sacramento** Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C	35.2	4.7%	+1.2%	+0.7%	-0.6%	38 days
42	**Washington DC** Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C	33.8	4.1%	+3.5%	-3.2%	-2.1%	29 days
43	**Boston** Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C	33.6	3.9%	+3.6%	-0.8%	+2.9%	25 days
44	**Philadelphia** Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	C	33.1	4.3%	-1.4%	-0.3%	+1.2%	36 days
45	**Minneapolis** Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	33.1	4.5%	+1.6%	-0.1%	-1.1%	33 days
46	**Richmond** Richmond	C	33.0	3.7%	+2.6%	-0.5%	-0.3%	38 days
47	**Portland** Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C-	31.7	5.2%	+5.8%	-2.6%	-1.4%	47 days
48	**Riverside** Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C-	31.1	5.1%	+5.2%	+0.2%	-1.1%	54 days
49	**Louisville** Louisville-Jefferson County	C-	29.8	4.4%	+3.0%	-1.2%	-0.9%	38 days
50	**Jacksonville** Jacksonville	D	22.6	4.7%	+3.5%	-0.8%	-0.1%	58 days

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #1 OF 50

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

80.7th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	98
Unemployment	20% weight	90
Wage Growth	15% weight	58
Cost of Living	12% weight	86
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	90
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	52
Days on Market	5% weight	42
Office Economy	3% weight	98

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-2.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	44 days	median, +2.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 80.7th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score of 8.10, and its strong office economy, with a professional worker share of 4.42. The labor demand is driven by a 2.04% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.947% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has a labor demand composite score of 8.10, driven by a 2.04% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.947% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a thriving economy. The top-tier percentile rank of 98th confirms the city's strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary is 3.00%, placing it in the top tier with a 90th percentile rank. This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate puts upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Raleigh-Cary is 4.32%, ranking it near the median with a 58th percentile rank. While this rate is not exceptionally high, it still indicates moderate wage growth, which can lead to rising labor costs for employers. However, this also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living percentile rank of 86th, making it relatively affordable compared to its peers. The city's price-to-salary ratio is 5.74, with a PSF of $218/sqft that has decreased by 2.2% year-over-year, compared to an hourly wage of $37.96. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary has grown by 1.72% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential employees, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Raleigh-Cary has decreased by 2.03% year-over-year, ranking it near the median with a 52nd percentile rank. This decline in permits may signal a tightening of the housing supply, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation in the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Raleigh-Cary is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.3%. While this increase may indicate a slightly slower market, the near-median percentile rank of 42nd suggests that the market is still relatively competitive. However, this can make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with a top-tier percentile rank of 98th. The city's strong office economy makes it an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the potential tightening of the housing supply, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation in the city.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #2 OF 50

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

A+

EXCELLENT

74.9th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	78
Unemployment	20% weight	82
Wage Growth	15% weight	66
Cost of Living	12% weight	88
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	86
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	42
Days on Market	5% weight	66
Office Economy	3% weight	82

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-7.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	49 days	median, +6.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 74.9th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 78th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranking in the 88th percentile. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and an attractive environment for talent.

Labor Demand

The Atlanta metro area has seen employment growth of 0.36% year-over-year, combined with a 0.816% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.62 further reinforces this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta stands at 3.30%, placing it in the top tier with an 82nd percentile rank. This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. However, it also indicates a strong local economy with high demand for labor.

Wage Growth

Wages in Atlanta have grown by 5.18% year-over-year, a rate that is above average, ranking in the 66th percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $198/sqft to $37.62/hr, Atlanta ranks in the 88th percentile for affordability, indicating that it is more affordable than most of its peer cities. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Atlanta has grown by 1.37% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier with an 86th percentile rank. This expansion in labor force supply means that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find and attract talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Atlanta has decreased by 7.48% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply may tighten in the future, potentially affecting affordability and the ability to attract and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Atlanta currently sit on the market for a median of 49 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.5%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home and the market is less competitive.

Office Economy

Atlanta's professional and office worker share ranks in the 82nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. This makes the city an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

In conclusion, Atlanta offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an excellent location for a wide range of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential tightening of the housing supply due to declining building permits, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #3 OF 50

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A+

EXCELLENT

73.1th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	62
Unemployment	20% weight	78
Wage Growth	15% weight	92
Cost of Living	12% weight	96
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	74
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	22
Days on Market	5% weight	86
Office Economy	3% weight	92

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-19.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	51 days	median, +15.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.1th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its exceptional wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.75%, and its highly affordable cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.24. These two metrics signal a strong and attractive labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 1.13% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -1.208% from the city's own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running slightly below trend, indicating a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 4.67 further supports this assessment, ranking above average at the 62th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 3.40%, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. However, the low unemployment rate also suggests that the city has a skilled and employed workforce, which can be beneficial for businesses looking to tap into a talented labor pool.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 7.75%, ranking at the 92th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing worker purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive, while also benefiting from a workforce with growing disposable income.

Cost of Living

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has a cost of living percentile rank of 96th, indicating that it is highly affordable relative to its peers. The city's PSF to wages ratio is 6.24, with PSF decreasing by 7.7% year-over-year. This affordability advantage makes the city an attractive destination for talent, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring excessive wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is growing at a rate of 0.81% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This expansion of the labor force supply indicates that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has decreased by 19.65% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 22th percentile. This decline in building permits signals a potential tightening of the housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 15.9%. This ranks at the 86th percentile, indicating a relatively slow market. For workers relocating to the city, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market, making it easier to find and secure a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is ranked at the 92th percentile, indicating a deep and talented pool of knowledge-economy workers. This makes the city an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, affordable cost of living, and a talented labor pool, making it an attractive destination for investment and expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential tightening of the housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #4 OF 50

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

68.7th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	58
Unemployment	20% weight	72
Wage Growth	15% weight	88
Cost of Living	12% weight	90
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	64
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	82
Days on Market	5% weight	8
Office Economy	3% weight	26

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+34.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	41 days	median, -12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 68.7th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.99%, and its highly affordable cost of living, with a percentile rank of 90th. These metrics signal a city with a competitive labor market and attractive living conditions.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate is 0.04% year-over-year, combined with a 0.223% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.58, which is near the median. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor market is experiencing a moderate increase in jobs and working hours.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Kansas City is 3.90%, which corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 72nd. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. However, the unemployment rate is still low enough to exert some upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.99%, Kansas City is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking it in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also translates to strong purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in the potential for increasing labor costs when considering relocation.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living is highly affordable, with a percentile rank of 90th, due to its PSF of $199/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.79, resulting in a ratio of 5.56. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for companies looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is growing at a rate of 0.37% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking it at the 64th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply indicates that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to find and hire talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Kansas City has increased by 34.49% year-over-year, signaling a significant expansion in housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for its workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Kansas City is 41 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 12.8%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This fast-paced market means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share is below average, ranking it at the 26th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors, making it less suited for companies that require a deep knowledge-economy workforce. However, it may be more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, affordable living conditions, and a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for relocation or expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the fast-paced housing market, which may pose challenges for relocating workers to find suitable housing, potentially affecting talent attraction and retention strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #5 OF 50

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A

VERY GOOD

66.8th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	60
Unemployment	20% weight	92
Wage Growth	15% weight	40
Cost of Living	12% weight	82
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	40
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	76
Days on Market	5% weight	84
Office Economy	3% weight	60

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+19.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	37 days	median, +8.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 66.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate defining its current economic character. The city's labor demand composite score of 4.58 and unemployment rate of 3.70% are key metrics that shape its economic landscape. With an employment growth rate of 0.06% and weekly hours deviation of 0.198%, Cincinnati's economy is characterized by genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate of 0.06% and weekly hours deviation of 0.198% signal genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than the 12-month trend. This combination suggests that businesses are experiencing increased demand for their products or services, leading to a need for more labor. As a result, companies can expect to find a workforce that is engaged and motivated.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.70%, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 92nd percentile. This low unemployment rate indicates a tight labor market, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages as they compete for scarce labor, which could increase their labor costs.

Wage Growth

Cincinnati's year-over-year wage growth rate is 3.26%, which is near the median, ranking in the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are experiencing an increase in their purchasing power, which could boost local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati is relatively affordable, with a cost of living percentile rank of 82, and a price-to-salary ratio of $192/sqft to $35.21/hr, or 5.45. The fact that the price per square foot is falling by 0.5% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability. This makes Cincinnati an attractive location for talent, as workers can enjoy a relatively high standard of living without requiring excessive wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is shrinking, with a year-over-year growth rate of -0.39%, ranking in the 40th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply could create a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the workers they need. As a result, companies may need to invest in training and development programs to upskill their existing workforce.

Building Permits

Cincinnati is experiencing a significant increase in residential building permits, with a year-over-year change of 19.15%, ranking in the 76th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it will provide more options for workers to live in the city. As a result, businesses can expect to find a more stable and attractive environment for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cincinnati is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.8%, ranking in the 84th percentile. This slower pace of home sales makes the city's housing market more accessible to relocating workers, giving them more time to find a suitable home. As a result, businesses can expect to find a more competitive and attractive environment for their employees.

Office Economy

Cincinnati has a relatively deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 60. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a strong labor demand, low unemployment rate, and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the city's shrinking labor force supply is a significant risk that decision-makers should factor in, as it could create challenges for hiring and workforce development. Overall, Cincinnati is a viable option for businesses looking to establish or expand their operations in a city with a growing economy and a high quality of life.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #6 OF 50

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A

VERY GOOD

66.8th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	90
Unemployment	20% weight	88
Wage Growth	15% weight	54
Cost of Living	12% weight	69
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	38
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	8
Days on Market	5% weight	60
Office Economy	3% weight	90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	2.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-31.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	50 days	median, +6.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 66.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and low unemployment rate of 2.90%. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.35, combining a +0.84% employment growth rate and a +0.874% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its top-tier unemployment percentile rank of 88th, defines the city's current economic character as one of robust job market activity.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.84% and weekly hours deviation of +0.874% from its own trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.35 further reinforces this, placing the city in the top tier of labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.90% is exceptionally low, ranking in the 88th percentile, which means the job market is very tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have significant bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.94% is moderate, ranking in the 54th percentile. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a manageable pace. For workers, this moderate wage growth translates into increased purchasing power, which can contribute to local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $262/sqft to $35.73/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.1% in PSF, the city ranks in the 69th percentile for affordability. This means the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, which can be a significant advantage for attracting talent without needing to offer substantial wage premiums. The decreasing PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force has contracted by -0.40% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction suggests that the city may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the supply of available workers is not expanding. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to this reality.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -31.30%, a sharp decline that signals a tightening of future housing supply. This decrease in building permits suggests that affordability and workforce accommodation may become more challenging in the future, potentially impacting the city's attractiveness to relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

Homes are currently sitting on the market for 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.4%. This increase in days on market, coupled with the absolute level of 50 days, suggests a normalization of the housing market, making it slightly more accessible for relocating workers. However, the market remains relatively competitive.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 90th percentile for its share of office and professional workers. This makes Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge-economy talent. Conversely, it may be less suited for industries with primarily industrial or logistics roles.

The Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with low unemployment and a deep talent pool in professional sectors, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This could offset some of the city's current economic advantages and should be carefully considered in location decisions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #7 OF 50

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A

VERY GOOD

65.4th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	92
Unemployment	20% weight	98
Wage Growth	15% weight	8
Cost of Living	12% weight	39
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	96
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	60
Days on Market	5% weight	0
Office Economy	3% weight	46

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	2.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+6.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	25 days	median, -16.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.4th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and low unemployment rate, at 2.70%. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.41, combining a 1.88% employment growth rate and a -0.519% weekly hours deviation, suggests genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.88% and weekly hours deviation of -0.519% indicate that the city is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours running slightly below trend, suggesting a healthy and sustainable growth pace. This combination signals that the labor market is robust, with employers hiring and workers having more opportunities. The labor demand composite score of 6.41 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.70% is exceptionally low, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face significant competition for talent, potentially driving up wages and making it harder to staff open positions. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have strong bargaining power in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 0.60% is relatively stagnant, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power may be limited. This slow wage growth suggests that the cost environment for employers is relatively flat, but workers may not have strong bargaining power to demand higher wages. The implication is that businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of $254/sqft and average hourly earnings of $39.66/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.40, ranks in the 39th percentile, indicating that the city is moderately affordable relative to peers. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.6% YoY suggests that the city is becoming more affordable over time. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset the cost of living, providing a talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile, indicating that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly. This means that businesses have a growing pool of potential employees to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff open positions. The implication is that the city has a strong hiring capacity, with a growing and dynamic labor market.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 6.72%, ranking above average at the 60th percentile, indicating that housing supply is expanding. This suggests that the city is experiencing developer confidence, with new residential construction projects underway, which will improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increasing housing supply signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 25 days, with a year-over-year direction of -16.7%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 0th percentile, indicating a very competitive market where homes sell quickly. This means that workers relocating to this city may face a challenging and competitive housing market, making it difficult to find and secure housing. The rapid sales pace suggests that the market is hot, and relocating workers may need to act quickly to secure a home.

Office Economy

The city's office economy, with a professional and office worker share of 2.44, ranks near the median at the 46th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and office skills, but may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or deep talent pool. The city is likely well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors, but may not be the best fit for businesses with highly specialized labor requirements.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with low unemployment and expanding workforce supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and grow. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the highly competitive housing market, which may make it difficult for relocating workers to find and secure housing, potentially impacting recruitment and retention efforts.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #8 OF 50

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

A

VERY GOOD

63.9th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	68
Unemployment	20% weight	62
Wage Growth	15% weight	38
Cost of Living	12% weight	78
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	68
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	62
Days on Market	5% weight	74
Office Economy	3% weight	92

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+7.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	46 days	median, +7.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and cost of living. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.29, combining a 0.92% employment growth rate and a -0.301% weekly hours deviation, suggests a genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its cost of living, with a PSF of $203/sqft and a ratio of 5.39 to hourly earnings of $37.69, ranks in the 78th percentile for affordability.

Labor Demand

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.92% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.301%, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and, although hours are slightly below trend, it is not indicative of a survivor squeeze. The labor demand composite score of 5.29 is in the 68th percentile, suggesting a strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 3.90%, ranking in the 62nd percentile, which indicates a relatively tight market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate can lead to wage pressure. However, it also suggests a strong local economy with a high level of labor utilization.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 3.13%, which is below average, ranking in the 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit slowly. This could be beneficial for businesses looking to manage labor costs while still attracting talent.

Cost of Living

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has a cost of living that ranks in the 78th percentile for affordability, with a PSF of $203/sqft and a ratio of 5.39 to hourly earnings of $37.69. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.5% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability. This makes the city an attractive location for talent, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing significant premiums to account for the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is growing at a rate of 0.52% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking in the 68th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential employees. This growth in labor force supply can help alleviate hiring challenges and support business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is increasing by 7.46% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking in the 62nd percentile. This rise in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and support workforce accommodation in the future. This is a positive sign for businesses concerned about the ability of their employees to find housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.0%, ranking in the 74th percentile. This indicates a slower market, which can make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the relatively fast pace of sales still suggests a competitive market, and businesses may need to consider this when relocating employees.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is ranked in the 92nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for a variety of industries. However, the relatively tight labor market and moderate wage growth rate may pose challenges for businesses looking to hire and manage labor costs, and decision-makers should factor in these considerations when evaluating the city as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #9 OF 50

Birmingham

Birmingham

A-

GOOD

61.0th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	84
Unemployment	20% weight	94
Wage Growth	15% weight	2
Cost of Living	12% weight	29
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	62
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	74
Days on Market	5% weight	40
Office Economy	3% weight	62

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	2.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+18.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	52 days	median, +4.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 61.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 84th percentile, and its low unemployment rate of 2.70%, ranking it in the top tier at the 94th percentile. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and intense competition for labor.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate is +0.67% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation from trend is +0.728%, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked above trend, suggesting that businesses are actively seeking to hire and expand their operations. The labor demand composite score of 5.97 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier at the 84th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham is 2.70%, which is extremely low and ranks in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face significant competition for workers, potentially driving up wages and making it more challenging to hire. As a result, companies looking to establish or expand operations in Birmingham may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Birmingham is -0.91%, which is stagnant and ranks in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers may be relatively flat, but it also implies that workers may have limited bargaining power and purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but they may also need to consider other benefits and incentives to attract and retain workers.

Cost of Living

Birmingham has a cost of living score that ranks in the 29th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $161/sqft to $32.82/hr, or 4.91. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. However, the fact that the PSF is only rising by 0.6% year-over-year may help to mitigate some of these costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is growing at a rate of +0.35% year-over-year, which ranks in the 62nd percentile. This moderate growth rate suggests that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit slowly, which could help to support hiring efforts by businesses.

However, the relatively slow growth rate may also limit the pool of available workers, making it essential for companies to offer competitive compensation and benefits.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Birmingham is increasing by +18.48% year-over-year, which ranks in the 74th percentile. This significant growth in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could help to improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain workers, as the availability of housing options increases.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Birmingham is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of +4.0%, ranking in the 40th percentile. This relatively moderate days on market suggests that the housing market is neither extremely competitive nor extremely slow, making it accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may indicate a slight normalization of the market, which could help to prevent overheating.

Office Economy

Birmingham's office economy is ranked in the 62nd percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 3.04. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool in these sectors, making it suitable for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. However, the city may be less suited for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a business a thriving job market with strong labor demand and a highly competitive workforce. However, the city's low unemployment rate and slow wage growth also present challenges for businesses looking to hire and retain top talent. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for intense competition for labor, which could drive up wages and make it challenging to attract and retain workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #10 OF 50

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

A-

GOOD

60.3th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	96
Unemployment	20% weight	74
Wage Growth	15% weight	14
Cost of Living	12% weight	0
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	94
Days on Market	5% weight	48
Office Economy	3% weight	86

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+104.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	28 days	median, +16.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 60.3th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier percentile rank of 96th, and its extremely high cost of living, ranking at the 0th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend, signaling genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.56% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of 0.747% above its own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours worked above trend. The labor demand composite score of 7.23 further reinforces this signal, indicating a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 3.90%, ranking at the 74th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in this market is that they may face some competition for talent, but it is still possible to find qualified candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 0.76%, ranking at the 14th percentile. This indicates stagnant wage growth, which may help keep labor costs flat for employers but also means workers have limited bargaining power. The slow wage growth may make it easier for businesses to manage labor costs, but it also means workers may have less purchasing power.

Cost of Living

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a cost of living ratio of $846/sqft to $54.37/hr, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.4% in PSF. However, with a percentile rank of 0th, the city is extremely expensive relative to peers. This makes it challenging to attract talent without offering significant wage premiums, as the high cost of living may offset the benefits of working in the area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a year-over-year growth rate of -0.11%, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This indicates a slightly contracting labor force supply, which may create a structural headwind for hiring in the future. The implication for hiring capacity is that businesses may need to be more competitive in their offers to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a year-over-year change in building permits of 104.08%, ranking at the 94th percentile. This indicates a significant expansion in housing supply, which may improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. The rapid growth in building permits signals developer confidence and a potential easing of the housing shortage.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area is 28 days, with a year-over-year increase of 16.7%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, although the increase in days on market may signal a healthy normalization. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is still competitive, but the slight increase in days on market may make it slightly more accessible.

Office Economy

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share ranking at the 86th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies. The city's strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses looking to tap into a knowledgeable and skilled workforce.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a deep professional talent pool, and a growing housing supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely high cost of living, which may require significant wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #11 OF 50

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

A-

GOOD

60.2th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	86
Unemployment	20% weight	10
Wage Growth	15% weight	80
Cost of Living	12% weight	61
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	94
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	10
Days on Market	5% weight	86
Office Economy	3% weight	88

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-25.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	51 days	median, +15.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 60.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 86th percentile, and its high wage growth rate of 6.16% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a thriving job market and increasing labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 1.46% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.319%. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs and hours are running slightly below trend, indicating a healthy and sustainable labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.03 further supports this assessment, ranking in the top tier at 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 5.40%, ranking in the bottom tier at 10th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire and potentially driving up wage pressure. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 6.16%, ranking in the top tier at 80th percentile. This represents fast wage growth, which may lead to increasing labor costs for employers. However, it also translates to strong worker purchasing power, making the city an attractive location for businesses that rely on a skilled and motivated workforce.

Cost of Living

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has a cost of living percentile rank of 61, with a price-to-salary ratio of $265/sqft to $33.40/hr, or 7.93. The city's cost of living is relatively average, but the fact that PSF is falling by 2.2% year-over-year suggests some improvement in affordability. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is growing at a rate of 2.43% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at 94th percentile. This indicates an expanding labor force supply, which should support hiring capacity and provide businesses with a larger pool of potential employees. As the labor force continues to grow, companies can expect to find the talent they need to drive their operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has decreased by 25.89% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at 10th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses should be aware of the potential for increasing housing costs and plan accordingly.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is currently 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 15.9%. This represents a relatively slow market, ranking in the top tier at 86th percentile. For workers relocating to the city, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market, making it easier to find and purchase a home.

Office Economy

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 88. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which rely on a skilled and knowledgeable workforce. However, it may be less suitable for companies in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of labor force.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a thriving job market, high wage growth, and a relatively average cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, companies should carefully consider their housing and labor costs when evaluating this city as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #12 OF 50

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

59.0th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	82
Unemployment	20% weight	76
Wage Growth	15% weight	6
Cost of Living	12% weight	45
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	78
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	30
Days on Market	5% weight	76
Office Economy	3% weight	80

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **-0.0%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.9%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-14.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **45 days** median, +7.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking in the 59.0th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with an employment growth rate of 0.88% and weekly hours 0.398% above its own trend, as well as its deep professional talent pool, ranking in the 80th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 5.93 places it in the top tier, at the 82nd percentile.

Labor Demand

The combination of 0.88% employment growth and 0.398% higher weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion in the Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area. This indicates that jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, suggesting a healthy and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.93, ranking in the 82nd percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia stands at 3.70%, ranking in the 76th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is -0.04%, ranking in the 6th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also suggests that workers may have limited bargaining power and purchasing power may not be increasing. This could impact the local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $220/sqft to $37.43/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.8% in PSF, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia ranks in the 45th percentile for affordability. This near-median ranking suggests that the city is neither extremely affordable nor extremely expensive, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent. However, the falling PSF relative to wages is a positive sign for affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is growing at a rate of 1.13% year-over-year, ranking in the 78th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is increasing, and the labor pool is becoming more diverse and larger.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -14.84%, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the future affordability and workforce accommodation in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.1%, ranking in the 76th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is becoming more accessible for relocating workers, as homes are taking slightly longer to sell. However, the market is still relatively competitive, and workers may face some challenges in finding available housing.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking in the 80th percentile, Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy roles, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, and could require businesses to offer wage premiums or other incentives to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #13 OF 50

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

58.5th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	34
Unemployment	20% weight	66
Wage Growth	15% weight	84
Cost of Living	12% weight	57
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	82
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	48
Days on Market	5% weight	60
Office Economy	3% weight	44

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-4.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	50 days	median, +6.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 58.5th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.43%, and its labor force growth, which is expanding at a rate of 1.20% annually. These metrics suggest a city with a growing workforce and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.61% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.767% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.45, which ranks below average at the 34th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours are below trend. This scenario may lead to a surplus of workers, making it easier for businesses to hire.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 4.00%, ranking above average at the 66th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that there is less slack in the market, making it harder for businesses to hire, and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. Businesses looking to hire in Pittsburgh may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Pittsburgh's year-over-year wage growth rate is 6.43%, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees will have more disposable income to spend on goods and services. However, it may pose a challenge for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living, with a PSF of $171/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.29/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.14, ranks near the median at the 57th percentile. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising 3.0% year-over-year may make it less attractive for talent without wage premiums, as the cost of living is increasing.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 1.20% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential employees, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Pittsburgh is decreasing at a rate of -4.03% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in building permits may signal future affordability challenges and limitations in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially making it harder for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Pittsburgh is 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.4%, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively longer period, making it a more accessible market for workers relocating to the city. However, this may also indicate a slowing market, which could have implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share ranks near the median at the 44th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent in these sectors. This makes the city suitable for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers, but it may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers a growing workforce and strong wage growth, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to expand their operations. However, the city's tightening housing supply and rising cost of living may pose challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain talent, and this should be a key consideration for decision-makers evaluating Pittsburgh as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #14 OF 50

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

58.5th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	80
Unemployment	20% weight	54
Wage Growth	15% weight	62
Cost of Living	12% weight	55
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	26
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	50
Days on Market	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	96

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-3.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	44 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Salt Lake City-Murray has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 58.5th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 80th percentile, driven by employment growth and hours worked above trend. Specifically, the city's employment growth rate of 1.08% and weekly hours deviation of 0.047% signal genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.08% employment growth rate and 0.047% weekly hours deviation above trend indicates genuine demand expansion in Salt Lake City-Murray. This suggests that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked increasing to meet the demand. As a result, businesses can expect to find a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack. For businesses trying to hire, this means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find talent, there is still some competition for workers, and wage pressure may be moderate.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.93%, Salt Lake City-Murray is experiencing above-average wage growth, ranking at the 62nd percentile. This signals rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect to benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Salt Lake City-Murray has a cost of living score ranking near the median at the 55th percentile, with a PSF-to-earnings ratio of $265/sqft to $39.31/hr, or 6.74. This indicates that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive relative to peers. For talent attraction, this means that businesses may not have a significant advantage in terms of cost of living, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray is contracting at a rate of -0.68% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 26th percentile. This suggests that the labor pool is shrinking, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the future. Businesses may need to plan for potential labor shortages and develop strategies to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Salt Lake City-Murray has decreased by 3.28% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This indicates that housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which may lead to tightening affordability and accommodation options for the workforce in the future. Businesses should factor in potential housing constraints when considering relocation or expansion.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 44 days, with no year-over-year change. This suggests a relatively stable and accessible housing market for workers relocating to the city. However, the below-average percentile rank of 26 indicates that the market may be slightly slower than average, which could be beneficial for buyers but may also signal weakening demand.

Office Economy

With an office economy score ranking at the 96th percentile, Salt Lake City-Murray has a deep and specialized talent pool, making it well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, this also means that the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Salt Lake City-Murray offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, above-average wage growth, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the city's shrinking labor force and potential housing constraints pose significant risks that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for relocation or expansion.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #15 OF 50

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

56.6th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	76
Unemployment	20% weight	50
Wage Growth	15% weight	76
Cost of Living	12% weight	16
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	28
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	66
Days on Market	5% weight	50
Office Economy	3% weight	78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**4.3%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+5.9%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.0%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**-0.7%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**+12.4%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**38 days**	median, +2.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 56.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score at the 76th percentile, and its high wage growth rate of 5.93% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a strong and expanding job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 0.98% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.076%, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in slightly fewer hours than expected, suggesting a healthy and sustainable pace of growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.60 further reinforces this assessment, ranking at the 76th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.30%, which is near the median among US metros, ranking at the 50th percentile. This suggests that the job market has some slack, but not excessively so, making it relatively manageable for businesses to hire workers. However, the moderate unemployment rate may not provide as much downward pressure on wages as a higher rate would.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 5.93%, which is above average, ranking at the 76th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but they can also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living score ranking at the 16th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $605 per square foot to $43.22 per hour, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The fact that the price per square foot is falling by 4.1% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains low. This suggests that attracting talent may require wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is shrinking by 0.65% year-over-year, ranking at the 28th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply implies that hiring capacity may be constrained, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit workers. As a result, companies may need to invest more in talent development and retention.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is increasing by 12.45% year-over-year, ranking at the 66th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that the city is taking steps to address its housing needs. As a result, businesses can expect a more stable and affordable housing market for their workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.7%, ranking at the 50th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor excessively slow. For workers relocating to the city, this means that they can expect a moderately accessible housing market.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking at the 78th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries that rely heavily on industrial or logistics workers.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a strong and expanding job market, with above-average labor demand and high wage growth. However, the city's relatively high cost of living and shrinking labor force supply are significant constraints that decision-makers should factor into their location decisions, potentially requiring wage premiums and targeted talent development strategies to attract and retain workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #16 OF 50

Columbus

Columbus

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.4th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	50
Unemployment	20% weight	96
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	74
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	42
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	2
Days on Market	5% weight	96
Office Economy	3% weight	38

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-41.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, +16.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B+ and a composite score ranking it at the 55.4th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.40% and a cost of living that, while not the lowest, offers a relatively affordable environment with a PSF to earnings ratio of 6.03. The city's labor demand, however, is near median, with employment growth and weekly hours deviations signaling a mixed economic character. Specifically, the combination of a +0.49% employment growth rate and a -0.934% weekly hours deviation suggests a scenario that is not clearly indicative of genuine demand expansion or contraction.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Columbus is +0.49% year-over-year, accompanied by a -0.934% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline. This combination indicates that while there is some job growth, the hours worked are slightly below trend, suggesting a labor market that is not experiencing significant expansion or contraction pressures. The labor demand composite score of 4.05 places it near the median, reflecting this balanced but not particularly robust labor market condition.

Unemployment

Columbus boasts a low unemployment rate of 3.40%, ranking it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring due to the scarcity of available workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in this market, the low unemployment rate means that attracting and retaining talent may require competitive compensation packages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Columbus is +2.79%, which is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at a rapid pace. For workers, this means their purchasing power is growing, albeit slowly, which could have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 74th, Columbus is more affordable than many of its peers, considering its PSF of $206/sqft is decreasing by -1.4% year-over-year relative to average hourly earnings of $34.14. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor for businesses, as it allows them to offer competitive salaries without needing large wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is growing at a rate of -0.33% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor pool. This negative growth rate suggests that the supply of potential workers is not expanding, which could pose a structural headwind for businesses looking to hire and expand their operations in the area.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -41.29%, placing Columbus in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This sharp decline in building permits signals a tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for the workforce to find accommodation, potentially affecting future business growth and relocation decisions.

Days on Market

Homes in Columbus are currently sitting on the market for 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +16.1%. This longer days on market, ranking at the 96th percentile, indicates a slower market that is more buyer-friendly. For workers relocating to the city, this could mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market, potentially easing the transition process.

Office Economy

Columbus has a professional and office worker share that ranks below average at the 38th percentile. This suggests that while there is some depth to the professional talent pool, the city may not be as well-suited for businesses requiring a large number of specialized tech, finance, or consulting roles. Instead, it might be more accommodating to industries with less specialized labor needs.

In conclusion, Columbus offers businesses a unique blend of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and relatively affordable living costs, making it an attractive location for talent acquisition without excessive wage premiums. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, signaling a potential future affordability crisis and housing supply squeeze that could impact workforce accommodation and business expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #17 OF 50

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B

AVERAGE

54.2th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	74
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	68
Cost of Living	12% weight	4
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	32
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	96
Days on Market	5% weight	58
Office Economy	3% weight	72

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.8%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.2%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.5%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+112.6%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **46 days** median, +4.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 54.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.46, which combines a 1.83% employment growth rate and a -1.401% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the office economy's 72nd percentile rank highlights the city's deep professional talent pool.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.83% and weekly hours deviation of -1.401% indicate that the city is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running slightly below trend. This combination suggests that the labor market is growing, but not at an unsustainable pace. The labor demand composite score of 5.46 is above average, ranking 74th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.80% is below average, ranking 36th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.19% is above average, ranking 68th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs when operating in this city.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is relatively expensive, with a percentile rank of 4th, due to a PSF of $667/sqft and average hourly earnings of $41.74/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.98. However, the PSF is falling by 3.3% year-over-year, which slightly mitigates the expense. The low affordability score means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living may deter some workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.54% year-over-year, ranking 32nd percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to accommodate this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 112.64%, ranking 96th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This rapid growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.5%, ranking 58th percentile. This relatively moderate pace of home sales means that the market is neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible for relocating workers. The rising days on market may indicate a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The office economy in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is deep, with a percentile rank of 72nd, indicating a strong presence of professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the city's relatively high cost of living and shrinking labor force growth pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #18 OF 50

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B

AVERAGE

50.7th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	46
Unemployment	20% weight	10
Wage Growth	15% weight	98
Cost of Living	12% weight	37
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	22
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	90
Days on Market	5% weight	92
Office Economy	3% weight	76

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+8.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+42.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	34 days	median, +13.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its high wage growth and strong building permits activity. The city's economic character is defined by its top-tier wage growth of 8.13% year-over-year and its significant increase in building permits, up 42.78% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a strong, growing economy, but also one with potential labor cost and affordability challenges.

Labor Demand

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an employment growth rate of -0.09% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.192% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.98, which ranks near the median at the 46th percentile. This combination signals a slight survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The near-median ranking indicates a relatively stable labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 4.90%, ranking at the 10th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 8.13%, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating very fast wage growth. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living score that ranks at the 37th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $452/sqft to $47.67/hr, or 9.48, which is below average. The city's cost of living is relatively expensive, but the -2.8% year-over-year change in PSF suggests some improvement in affordability. This means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is growing at a rate of -0.80% year-over-year, ranking at the 22nd percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has increased by 42.78% year-over-year, ranking at the 90th percentile, signaling a significant expansion in housing supply. This increase suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, as more housing units become available. The strong growth in building permits is a positive indicator for the city's future economic development.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 34 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.3%, ranking at the 92nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, the slower market may make it easier to find a home, but it also suggests a less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a professional and office worker share of 3.36, ranking at the 76th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a strong, growing economy with a highly skilled workforce, but also presents challenges such as rapid wage growth and a relatively expensive cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential labor cost increase due to the tight labor market and fast wage growth, which may impact businesses' bottom line and require adjustments to their compensation strategies.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #19 OF 50

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B

AVERAGE

50.5th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	72
Unemployment	20% weight	68
Wage Growth	15% weight	82
Cost of Living	12% weight	20
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	6
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	12
Days on Market	5% weight	6
Office Economy	3% weight	68

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-25.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	31 days	median, -6.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 50.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.40, combining a +0.20% employment growth rate and a +0.817% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the +6.20% year-over-year wage growth rate highlights a competitive labor market.

Labor Demand

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.20% and a weekly hours deviation of +0.817% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.40, ranking in the 72nd percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 4.00%, ranking in the 68th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market implies that workers have more bargaining power, which can drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is +6.20%, ranking in the 82nd percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This rapid increase in wages suggests that labor costs for employers will rise, but it also means that workers will have more purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses. The strong wage growth is a double-edged sword, offering benefits to workers but increasing costs for employers.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living percentile rank of 20, indicating that it is relatively expensive, with a PSF of $662/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $50.86/hr, resulting in a ratio of 13.02. However, the PSF is falling by 3.1% year-over-year, which is a key driver of affordability. Despite this, the city's high cost of living may deter some talent, requiring businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is shrinking at a rate of -1.40% year-over-year, ranking in the 6th percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent. The shrinking labor pool may lead to increased competition for workers, driving up labor costs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has decreased by 25.29% year-over-year, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decline in building permits suggests that the city's housing market may become less affordable in the future, posing a risk to workforce accommodation and attraction. The decrease in permits may exacerbate the city's existing affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 31 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 6.1%, ranking in the 6th percentile. This indicates a competitive housing market, where homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find accommodation. The fast-paced market may require workers to act quickly to secure housing, which can be stressful and competitive.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 3.12, ranking in the 68th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge-economy talent. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and fast wage growth, but it also poses significant challenges, including a tight labor market, high cost of living, and shrinking labor pool. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's affordability and housing supply challenges, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums and navigate a competitive housing market to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #20 OF 50

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

B

AVERAGE

50.1th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	14
Unemployment	20% weight	64
Wage Growth	15% weight	86
Cost of Living	12% weight	94
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	10
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	40
Days on Market	5% weight	90
Office Economy	3% weight	6

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-9.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	51 days	median, +18.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and affordable cost of living, scoring 86th and 94th percentiles respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, with wage growth at 6.84% year-over-year and a cost of living ratio of $173/sqft to $34.04/hr, indicating a highly affordable environment. This unique combination sets Oklahoma City apart from its peers.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is -0.87% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.444% from its own trend, signaling a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This indicates that while there may be some demand for labor, the overall job market is contracting. The labor demand composite score of 2.64 falls in the bottom tier, 14th percentile, reflecting this challenging environment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 3.40%, ranking in the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to find talent, there could still be some competition for skilled workers, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.84%, Oklahoma City experiences fast wage growth, ranking in the 86th percentile. This rapid increase in wages implies rising labor costs for employers but also enhances worker purchasing power, contributing to a robust local economy. Businesses should factor in these increasing labor costs when considering relocation or expansion in Oklahoma City.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City is highly affordable, with a cost of living score in the 94th percentile, driven by a PSF to earnings ratio of $173/sqft to $34.04/hr, and a year-over-year decrease in PSF of -0.6%. This affordability advantage is a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing substantial premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is contracting at a rate of -1.21% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential employees is decreasing, which could exacerbate challenges in finding and retaining talent.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Oklahoma City have decreased by -9.74% year-over-year, suggesting that housing supply is not expanding as rapidly as in other cities, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This slowdown in new housing development could lead to a future supply squeeze, potentially affecting affordability and the ability to attract and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Oklahoma City currently sit on the market for a median of 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 18.6%, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to this city, the slower pace of home sales could make the housing market more accessible, providing more time to find suitable housing without facing intense competition.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional and office worker share is relatively low, ranking in the 6th percentile, suggesting a less deep talent pool in these sectors. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring a high concentration of tech, finance, consulting, or HQ functions, but it may still support industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers businesses a unique blend of strong wage growth and an extremely affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent retention and attraction without the need for significant wage premiums. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's contracting labor force and slow housing development, which could limit the availability of skilled workers and affect future affordability and workforce accommodation.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #21 OF 50

Memphis

Memphis

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.9th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	18
Unemployment	20% weight	58
Wage Growth	15% weight	64
Cost of Living	12% weight	98
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	24
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	88
Days on Market	5% weight	24
Office Economy	3% weight	2

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+39.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	54 days	median, -3.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 49.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked in the top tier at 98th percentile. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 2.94 and the cost of living ratio of $155/sqft to $32.13/hr, with a PSF decline of 6.1% YoY, set the tone for this market.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.03% YoY and weekly hours 1.318% above its own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine expansion. This combination suggests a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 2.94, ranked in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.20%, ranking near the median at 58th percentile. This indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

Memphis has a year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.99%, ranked above average at 64th percentile. This represents moderately fast wage growth, which will lead to rising labor costs for employers but also increase worker purchasing power. As a result, businesses may face higher costs, but workers will have more disposable income.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $155/sqft to $32.13/hr and a PSF decline of 6.1% YoY, Memphis is highly affordable, ranked in the top tier at 98th percentile. This affordability advantage will attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to hire.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is shrinking at a rate of -0.76% YoY, ranked below average at 24th percentile. This contraction in labor supply will create a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the workers they need.

Building Permits

Memphis has seen a 39.08% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranked in the top tier at 88th percentile. This expansion in housing supply will improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce, signaling a positive outlook for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

Homes in Memphis currently sit on the market for 54 days, with a year-over-year decline of 3.6%. This relatively fast market, ranked below average at 24th percentile, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, potentially impacting a business's ability to attract talent.

Office Economy

Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranked in the bottom tier at 2nd percentile. This makes it less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, like logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a moderate unemployment rate, but its low labor demand and shrinking labor force pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk for a decision-maker is the potential difficulty in finding and hiring the necessary workers due to the contracting labor supply, which could constrain business growth and expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #22 OF 50

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.4th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	66
Unemployment	20% weight	28
Wage Growth	15% weight	26
Cost of Living	12% weight	71
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	60
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	24
Days on Market	5% weight	78
Office Economy	3% weight	84

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-18.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	48 days	median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 49.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score at the 66th percentile, and its relatively affordable cost of living, ranked at the 71st percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 0.54% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.068% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.54% and the -0.068% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend signal a genuine demand expansion, as hours are not significantly above trend despite job growth. This combination indicates that the labor market is experiencing a moderate expansion. The labor demand composite score of 4.99 further supports this assessment, ranking at the 66th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 4.40%, which is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is 2.05%, which is below average, ranking at the 26th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit gradually. This may lead to a relatively stable labor cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 4.72, based on $173/sqft (decreasing by 2.3% year-over-year) and $36.67/hr, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is relatively affordable, ranking at the 71st percentile. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.29% year-over-year, indicating a moderate expansion of the workforce supply. This growth rate, ranking at the 60th percentile, suggests that the labor pool is increasing, providing a favorable environment for hiring.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -18.37%, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline, ranking at the 24th percentile, signals a potential future affordability constraint and may impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 48 days, with a 9.1% year-over-year increase. This increase, ranking at the 78th percentile, indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this may also signal a normalization of the market rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking at the 84th percentile, Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy roles, but may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate labor demand expansion, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and business growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, potentially limiting the city's long-term growth prospects.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #23 OF 50

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.4th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	32
Unemployment	20% weight	46
Wage Growth	15% weight	96
Cost of Living	12% weight	33
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	58
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	46
Days on Market	5% weight	14
Office Economy	3% weight	58

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+8.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-5.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	77 days	median, +6.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 48.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 8.02% year-over-year and its below-average labor demand composite score of 3.42, indicating a complex labor market. The combination of these metrics suggests that while wages are rising rapidly, the labor market itself is not expanding as quickly as peers.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -0.63% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.000%, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not increasing significantly despite job losses. The labor market is experiencing a slight contraction, which may lead to a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.70%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced labor market with some slack, making it neither extremely tight nor overly loose. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that finding talent may not be excessively difficult, but it also may not drive significant wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 8.02%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This fast wage growth indicates rising labor costs for employers but also strong worker purchasing power. As wages continue to rise, businesses may face increasing costs, but the local workforce will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score ranking it below average at the 33rd percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $359/sqft to $34.20/hr, or 10.50. Although the PSF is falling by 1.6% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to peers. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging due to the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of 0.15% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This slow growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, but at a modest pace. The implication for hiring capacity is that while there is some growth, it may not be sufficient to meet rapid business expansion needs.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -5.72%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is not expanding as quickly as in other cities, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 77 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.9%. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For a worker relocating to this city, the slower market may make it easier to find a home, but it also signals a less competitive and potentially less dynamic local economy.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach ranks near the median at the 58th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy with a balance of professional and non-professional roles, but it may not be ideal for those requiring a highly specialized or purely knowledge-based workforce.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers a unique combination of high wage growth and moderate labor market conditions, making it an attractive location for businesses that can navigate its complexities. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain top talent, potentially offsetting the benefits of the area's strong wage growth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #24 OF 50

Cleveland

Cleveland

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.4th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	48
Unemployment	20% weight	68
Wage Growth	15% weight	4
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	92
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	26
Days on Market	5% weight	46
Office Economy	3% weight	70

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-18.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	55 days	median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 48.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 4.01 and its bottom-tier wage growth of -0.25% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with labor demand neither strongly expanding nor contracting, but with notable downward pressure on wages.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is +0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -1.088% below the city's own trend. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend despite modest job growth. The labor market is not experiencing significant contraction, but the deviation in hours suggests some level of inefficiency or underutilization.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking it at the 68th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with potential upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent. However, the current wage growth rate does not support this expectation, suggesting other factors may be influencing the labor market.

Wage Growth

Cleveland's year-over-year wage growth rate is -0.25%, placing it in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This stagnant wage growth environment suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing significantly, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. This could have implications for consumer demand and the overall vitality of the local economy.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $143/sqft to $33.94/hr, Cleveland ranks near the median at the 50th percentile. This indicates that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. The cost of living is not a significant advantage or disadvantage for talent attraction, as the ratio, although not favorable, does not stand out as exceptionally high or low.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This expansion in labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which could facilitate hiring for businesses locating or expanding in the area. This growth is a positive indicator for the city's economic development.

Building Permits

Cleveland has experienced a -18.19% year-over-year change in residential building permits, ranking it below average at the 26th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is not expanding at a pace that keeps up with demand, potentially leading to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation. This could become a significant challenge for attracting and retaining talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.8%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which could be seen as more accessible for relocating workers, as they have more time to find suitable housing. However, this trend needs to be monitored, as significant changes could signal shifts in demand or supply dynamics.

Office Economy

Cleveland's share of professional and office workers places it above average at the 70th percentile. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or those looking to establish headquarters. The city is less suited for industries that are heavily industrial or logistics-dominant, given its stronger orientation towards knowledge-economy sectors.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a mixed economic environment with both opportunities and challenges. The city's growing labor force and deep professional talent pool are significant advantages. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges due to the decline in residential building permits, which could impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent over time.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #25 OF 50

Providence

Providence-Warwick

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.4th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	64
Unemployment	20% weight	20
Wage Growth	15% weight	50
Cost of Living	12% weight	2
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	88
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	98
Days on Market	5% weight	2
Office Economy	3% weight	64

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+132.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	27 days	median, -6.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 48.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth, with a year-over-year increase of 1.69%, and its extremely low affordability, with a cost of living ratio of 9.77, ranking it in the 2nd percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a growing workforce but significant challenges in attracting and retaining talent due to high costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is 0.60% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.451% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.69, which ranks in the 64th percentile. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. However, the relatively modest employment growth rate suggests that this demand expansion is not overly robust.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking it in the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With a tight market, employers may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Providence-Warwick is 3.77%, ranking it near the median at the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. As a result, businesses can expect to see some upward pressure on labor costs, but it is not likely to be a major constraint.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living ratio of 9.77, with a PSF of $359/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.75, ranking it in the 2nd percentile, indicating that the city is extremely expensive relative to peers. This low affordability ranking means that the city is at a significant disadvantage in terms of talent attraction, as workers may require wage premiums to offset the high cost of living. The 7.5% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of 1.69% year-over-year, ranking it in the 88th percentile, indicating that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly. This strong labor force growth suggests that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick has increased by 132.32% year-over-year, ranking it in the 98th percentile, indicating that housing supply is expanding rapidly. This surge in building permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve, as new housing stock comes online to meet growing demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is currently 27 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 6.9%, ranking it in the 2nd percentile, indicating a very competitive market. This fast-paced market means that relocating workers may face challenges in finding available housing, making it essential for businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract top talent.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy ranking in the 64th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a growing workforce and expanding housing supply, but its extremely low affordability and competitive housing market pose significant challenges for talent attraction and retention. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums or other incentives to attract and retain top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #26 OF 50

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

47.8th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	52
Unemployment	20% weight	78
Wage Growth	15% weight	52
Cost of Living	12% weight	6
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	0
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	56
Days on Market	5% weight	94
Office Economy	3% weight	12

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-4.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-0.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	37 days	median, +12.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 47.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor force growth rate of -4.53% YoY and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.85, ranking it in the 6th percentile for affordability. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -0.13% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.798% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.12, which ranks near the median at 52nd percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The near-median ranking indicates a relatively stable but unremarkable labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.00%, ranking it in the 78th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with relatively low unemployment. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +3.79%, ranking it near the median at 52nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses that rely on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living ranking in the 6th percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.85, indicating that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF is $222/sqft, which has increased by 7.2% YoY, making it even more challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The low affordability ranking suggests that businesses may need to consider offering higher salaries or other benefits to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -4.53% YoY, ranking it in the bottom tier at 0th percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and retain talent. The shrinking labor pool may lead to increased competition for workers and upward pressure on wages.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -0.59%, ranking it near the median at 56th percentile. This slight decline in permits suggests that housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. However, the near-median ranking indicates that the situation is not yet critical.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of 12.1%, ranking it in the top tier at 94th percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising DOM suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 0.86, ranking it in the bottom tier at 12th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses that require specialized office or professional skills, such as tech, finance, or consulting. The city may be better suited for businesses with more industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a relatively stable labor market and moderate wage growth, but its low labor force growth rate and high cost of living pose significant challenges for talent attraction and retention. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the shrinking labor pool, which may lead to increased competition for workers and upward pressure on wages, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully weigh these factors in their location decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #27 OF 50

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.7th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	94
Unemployment	20% weight	10
Wage Growth	15% weight	20
Cost of Living	12% weight	65
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	80
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	0
Days on Market	5% weight	16
Office Economy	3% weight	52

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-54.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	68 days	median, +9.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 46.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 94th percentile, and its low unemployment rate, which is in the bottom tier at 10th percentile with a rate of 4.40%. The combination of these two metrics suggests a competitive job market with strong demand for labor.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is +0.83% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.982% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, indicating that businesses are not only hiring but also increasing the workload for existing employees. This is a positive sign for companies looking to expand their operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 4.40%, which is in the bottom tier at 10th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent in this competitive job market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is +1.64%, which is below average at 20th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate. However, it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing rapidly, which could impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score that ranks 65th percentile, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. The price-to-salary ratio is $224/sqft vs $33.37/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.71. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor for businesses, as employees may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of +1.14% year-over-year, which is in the top tier at 80th percentile. This expanding labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential employees. However, the tight labor market may still pose challenges for companies trying to attract top talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has decreased by -54.27% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier at 0th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 68 days, with a year-over-year increase of +9.7%. This indicates a slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the area, as they may have more time to find a suitable home. However, this trend may also signal a normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has an office economy score that ranks 52nd percentile, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for a variety of businesses, but may not have the same level of specialization as other cities with deeper talent pools. As a result, companies in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors may find the city's talent pool adequate, but not exceptional.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and affordability, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand their operations. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #28 OF 50

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.0th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	42
Unemployment	20% weight	4
Wage Growth	15% weight	94
Cost of Living	12% weight	84
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	56
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	32
Days on Market	5% weight	12
Office Economy	3% weight	40

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-12.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	67 days	median, +15.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 46.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 7.84% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 4.50%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of these metrics suggests that while the city has a strong demand for labor, it may also face challenges in terms of hiring and retaining workers due to the competitive job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is -0.33% year-over-year, while weekly hours are running 0.096% above trend. This combination signals a slight contraction in labor demand, but with hours above trend, it may indicate a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 3.74 ranks at the 42nd percentile, indicating a near-median level of labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.50%, ranking at the 4th percentile, which means the market is extremely tight. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring and retaining workers, as the pool of available labor is limited. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 7.84%, ranking at the 94th percentile, which indicates fast wage growth. This rapid wage growth implies that employer labor costs are rising quickly, but it also means that workers have strong purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local businesses that rely on consumer spending. However, this may also lead to increased costs for businesses, which could impact their bottom line.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living score ranking at the 84th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $242/sqft to $38.19/hr, or 6.34. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, with a falling PSF value of -2.8% year-over-year. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living in the city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of 0.14% year-over-year, ranking at the 56th percentile. This slow growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, but at a moderate pace. While this growth is positive, it may not be sufficient to meet the demands of a rapidly growing business, which could lead to hiring challenges.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has decreased by 12.90% year-over-year, ranking at the 32nd percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This may impact the city's ability to attract and retain workers, particularly those who are relocating from other areas.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is currently 67 days, with a year-over-year increase of 15.5%. This increase in days on market, ranking at the 12th percentile, indicates a slower market, which may be more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this slower market may also indicate decreased demand for housing, which could have implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has an office economy score ranking at the 40th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.32 out of 5. This indicates a moderate depth of professional talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or deep talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth, low unemployment, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the tight labor market, which can make it challenging to hire and retain workers. Decision-makers should carefully consider this factor when evaluating the city as a potential location for their business.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #29 OF 50

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

46.0th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	30
Unemployment	20% weight	82
Wage Growth	15% weight	18
Cost of Living	12% weight	53
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	2
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	68
Days on Market	5% weight	82
Office Economy	3% weight	66

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-2.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+12.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, +8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 46.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score at the 30th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.70% ranking at the 82nd percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is -0.44% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.319% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring new talent.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.70%, which ranks at the 82nd percentile, indicating a very tight market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for a limited pool of qualified candidates, leading to potential wage pressure. As a result, companies may need to offer higher salaries or benefits to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +1.57%, which ranks at the 18th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but it also suggests that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but they may also not see significant increases in consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score ranking at the 53rd percentile, with a PSF of $293/sqft and average hourly earnings of $42.41/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.91. This means that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither particularly expensive nor inexpensive compared to its peers. As a result, businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent, but they also may not have a significant advantage in terms of cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is contracting at a rate of -2.34% year-over-year, ranking at the 2nd percentile. This means that the supply of potential workers is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. As a result, companies may face significant challenges in finding qualified candidates, and may need to consider alternative locations or strategies for talent acquisition.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is increasing at a rate of +12.87% year-over-year, ranking at the 68th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. As a result, businesses may see a more stable and predictable housing market, which could support talent attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is currently 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.3%, ranking at the 82nd percentile. This suggests a slower market, which could make it easier for relocating workers to find and purchase homes. As a result, businesses may see a more accessible and attractive housing market for their employees, which could support talent recruitment and retention.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a professional and office worker share ranking at the 66th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in these sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. As a result, companies in these sectors may find a strong and supportive ecosystem in Denver-Aurora-Centennial.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a tight labor market with low unemployment, but also significant challenges in terms of labor demand and labor force growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which could limit the city's ability to support business expansion and growth. As a result, companies should carefully consider their talent acquisition and retention strategies when evaluating Denver-Aurora-Centennial as a potential location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #30 OF 50

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

45.3th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	28
Unemployment	20% weight	56
Wage Growth	15% weight	36
Cost of Living	12% weight	92
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	48
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	34
Days on Market	5% weight	18
Office Economy	3% weight	54

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-12.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	53 days	median, -8.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.29 ranking it at the 28th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, with a ratio of $172/sqft to $32.72/hr and a percentile rank of 92. The labor demand metrics, including employment growth and weekly hours, signal a contraction in the job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +0.35% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -2.620% below the city's own trend. This combination signals a contraction in the job market, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The below-average labor demand composite score of 3.29 confirms this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 4.00%, ranking it at the 56th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This means that while the market is not extremely tight, it is also not overly loose, with some competition for jobs. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding qualified candidates may be manageable, but not extremely easy.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +3.05%, ranking it at the 36th percentile, indicating below-average wage growth. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly, while worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. As a result, businesses may face some upward pressure on wages, but it is not extreme.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a highly affordable cost of living, with a percentile rank of 92, due to its low PSF-to-earnings ratio of $172/sqft to $32.72/hr, which is falling by -5.5% year-over-year. This high affordability score means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring large wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is shrinking at a rate of -0.16% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 48th percentile. This contraction in the labor force supply suggests that hiring capacity may be limited in the future, as the pool of available workers is not expanding.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels is falling by -12.26% year-over-year, ranking it at the 34th percentile, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in building permits signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 53 days, with a year-over-year decline of -8.6%, ranking it at the 18th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests that the market is competitive, and relocating workers may face challenges in finding and securing housing.

Office Economy

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a professional talent pool that ranks at the 54th percentile, indicating a near-median depth of specialized workers. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require an extremely deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on a highly specialized workforce.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a highly affordable cost of living and a moderate unemployment rate, making it an attractive location for companies looking to reduce labor costs. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the below-average labor demand and shrinking labor force supply, which may limit hiring capacity and create challenges for businesses looking to expand or relocate to the area.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #31 OF 50

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.8th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	52
Unemployment	20% weight	16
Wage Growth	15% weight	56
Cost of Living	12% weight	63
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	20
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	78
Days on Market	5% weight	34
Office Economy	3% weight	36

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
5.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+4.2%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.9%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+29.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
34 days
median, +3.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, which is near median, and its unemployment rate, which is in the bottom tier at 16th percentile. Specifically, the labor demand composite score is 4.12, and the unemployment rate is 5.10%, indicating a complex labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is -0.13% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.150% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The near median percentile rank of 52nd indicates a relatively stable but unremarkable labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 5.10%, which is in the bottom tier at 16th percentile. This indicates a labor market with some slack, rather than a tight market. For a business trying to hire in this city, the relatively high unemployment rate means it may be easier to staff, but it also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +4.16%, which is near median at 56th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly. At the same time, worker purchasing power is increasing, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living percentile rank of 63rd, indicating that it is above average in terms of affordability. The PSF to earnings ratio is $217/sqft vs $37.50/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.79. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is -0.92%, which is below average at 20th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, rather than expanding. The implication for hiring capacity is that it may become more challenging to find qualified workers in the future.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +29.19%, which is above average at 78th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive signal for future workforce attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 34 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.0%. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the below average percentile rank of 34th suggests that the market may not be as competitive as others.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is below average, with a percentile rank of 36th. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool in these areas, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate wage growth rate, making it an attractive location for businesses that prioritize these factors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the contracting labor force supply, which may limit hiring capacity and workforce growth in the future.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #32 OF 50

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.6th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	22
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	78
Cost of Living	12% weight	18
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	70
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	92
Days on Market	5% weight	10
Office Economy	3% weight	42

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+64.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	41 days	median, -8.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.16 ranking it in the 22nd percentile, and its above-average wage growth of 6.12% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.63% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.253%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, with hours above trend during job losses indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding the right talent.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.50%, ranking it in the 36th percentile. This indicates a market with some slack, but not excessively so. For a business trying to hire in this area, this means that there may be a moderate pool of available workers, but wages may not be under significant downward pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in this metro area is 6.12%, ranking it in the 78th percentile. This is a relatively fast rate of wage growth, suggesting that employer labor costs are rising. However, this also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

This city has a cost of living score ranking it in the 18th percentile, with a PSF of $540/sqft and average hourly earnings of $41.45/hr, resulting in a ratio of 13.03. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.3% year-over-year is a positive sign, but overall, this city's high cost of living may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of 0.73% year-over-year, ranking it in the 70th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. This growth suggests that the city has a dynamic labor market with a growing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in this metro area is increasing by 64.22% year-over-year, ranking it in the 92nd percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. This is a positive sign for businesses that rely on a stable and affordable housing market for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in this area is 41 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -8.9%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The low percentile rank of 10th percentile suggests that homes are selling quickly, making it a competitive market for buyers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in this metro area ranks it in the 42nd percentile, with a composite score of 2.34. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool in these sectors, making it suitable for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations. However, it may not be as well-suited for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics sectors.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average wage growth and expanding labor force supply, but also poses challenges due to its below-average labor demand and high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the city's expensive housing market and relatively high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to remain competitive.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #33 OF 50

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.6th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	4
Unemployment	20% weight	44
Wage Growth	15% weight	90
Cost of Living	12% weight	59
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	36
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	86
Days on Market	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	22

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+7.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+38.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	35 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a 7.51% year-over-year increase, and its weak labor demand, with a -0.66% employment growth rate and a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier at 1.88. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is -0.66% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 1.552% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score is in the bottom tier at 1.88, indicating a weak job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced labor market, neither extremely tight nor slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate implies a manageable but not extremely favorable hiring environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 7.51%, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but strong worker purchasing power. Businesses operating in this city should be prepared for increasing labor costs.

Cost of Living

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk has a cost of living score ranking near the median at the 59th percentile, with a PSF of $223/sqft and average hourly earnings of $35.86/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.22. The city's cost of living is increasing, with PSF rising 2.3% year-over-year. This suggests that the city is not extremely affordable, and businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is growing at a rate of -0.41% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This indicates a contracting labor pool, which poses a structural headwind for hiring and may limit the city's ability to support business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is increasing by 38.19% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and support workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 35 days, with no year-over-year change. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which may be competitive for workers relocating to the city. However, the lack of change in days on market suggests a stable housing market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk ranks below average at the 22nd percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses requiring specialized office or professional workers, making the city less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a relatively balanced labor market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's weak labor demand and contracting labor pool, which may limit the city's ability to support business growth and require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #34 OF 50

Fresno

Fresno

C+

POOR

44.0th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	88
Unemployment	20% weight	0
Wage Growth	15% weight	60
Cost of Living	12% weight	24
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	46
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	18
Days on Market	5% weight	52
Office Economy	3% weight	34

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	8.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+2.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-22.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	50 days	median, +4.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44th out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an 88th percentile ranking, and its high unemployment rate, which stands at 8.90%. These two metrics signal a complex labor market with both opportunities and challenges.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 2.12% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation is -1.038% from its own trend. The combination of these two metrics signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs while its hours worked are slightly below trend, indicating that the growth is not solely due to existing workers taking on more hours. This suggests a healthy labor market with opportunities for businesses to expand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 8.90%, ranking it in the bottom tier. This indicates a labor market with significant slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

Fresno's year-over-year wage growth rate is 4.39%, ranking it above average at the 60th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace. Additionally, workers in Fresno are seeing an increase in their purchasing power, which could benefit businesses that rely on local consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score that ranks it below average at the 24th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $262/sqft to $32.14/hr, resulting in a ratio of 8.15. This means that Fresno is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is growing at a rate of -0.17% year-over-year, ranking it near the median. This slight contraction in the labor force supply suggests that hiring capacity may be limited in the future, making it essential for businesses to plan accordingly.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Fresno has decreased by 22.67% year-over-year, ranking it in the bottom tier. This significant decline in building permits signals a tightening of the housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Fresno is 50 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.2%. This suggests a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers to find housing. However, the rising days on market could also indicate a normalization of the market, which could benefit businesses looking to relocate workers to the city.

Office Economy

Fresno's professional and office worker share ranks it below average at the 34th percentile, with a composite score of 2.10. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

In conclusion, Fresno offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and a relatively slow housing market, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the city's high unemployment rate and limited labor force growth pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Fresno as a potential business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #35 OF 50

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

C+

POOR

43.3th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	38
Unemployment	20% weight	86
Wage Growth	15% weight	10
Cost of Living	12% weight	8
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	34
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	80
Days on Market	5% weight	44
Office Economy	3% weight	18

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.3%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+0.6%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.5%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**-0.5%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**+32.8%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**41 days**	median, +2.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.30% and stagnant wage growth of +0.62% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a tight labor market with limited room for wage growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis is -0.47% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.050%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the city is experiencing job losses while hours are slightly above trend, indicating a potential survivor squeeze. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding new talent to hire.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis is 3.30%, ranking it in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive wages or benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis is +0.62%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. This may impact the overall attractiveness of the city to businesses and workers alike.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis has a cost of living score ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, with a PSF of $168/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.45/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.02. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising by 5.7% year-over-year further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis is contracting at a rate of -0.50% year-over-year. This decline in labor force supply may create a structural headwind for hiring, making it even more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. As a result, businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to attract workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Indianapolis is increasing by 32.81% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that the city may become more attractive to workers and businesses in the long term.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Indianapolis is 41 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.5%. This suggests that the housing market is normalizing, but it may still be relatively competitive for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising DOM may indicate a slight easing of the market, making it more accessible to relocating workers.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Indianapolis is relatively low, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This suggests that the city may not have a deep talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors, making it less suited for HQ decisions or knowledge-economy businesses.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and relatively expensive cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the stagnant wage growth and declining labor force supply, which may create challenges in attracting and retaining top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #36 OF 50

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

C+

POOR

40.0th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	44
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	48
Cost of Living	12% weight	47
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	16
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	38
Days on Market	5% weight	38
Office Economy	3% weight	56

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-9.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	57 days	median, +9.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 40.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 3.98, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile, and its labor force growth rate of -0.96% per year, placing it in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with sluggish job market dynamics.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is -0.23% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.241% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as both job growth and hours worked are below trend. The labor demand composite score of 3.98 reflects this sluggishness, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 4.00%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +3.68%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in the area are experiencing a modest increase in purchasing power, which could support local economic activity.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $272/sqft to $37.45/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.26, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler ranks near the median at the 47th percentile in terms of affordability. Given that the PSF is falling -1.8% year-over-year, the city is becoming more affordable relative to wages. This makes it more attractive for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums, potentially offering a competitive advantage in talent attraction.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is shrinking at a rate of -0.96% per year, placing it in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has decreased by -9.77% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 38th percentile. This decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler are currently sitting on the market for a median of 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of +9.6%. This indicates a slowing market, making it slightly more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the relatively moderate days on market suggests that the housing market is not overly competitive, striking a balance between accessibility and demand.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 2.64, Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a near-median ranking at the 56th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city more suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or headquarters operations, but less ideal for industries requiring large industrial or logistics workforces.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers a business a moderately affordable cost of living and a labor market with some slack, but it is constrained by sluggish labor demand and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's limited capacity for hiring due to its contracting labor force, which could hinder business growth and expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #37 OF 50

St. Louis

St. Louis

C+

POOR

39.2th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	36
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	12
Cost of Living	12% weight	31
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	66
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	64
Days on Market	5% weight	80
Office Economy	3% weight	16

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+9.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	42 days	median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's current economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.49 ranking it in the 36th percentile, and its slow wage growth, with a year-over-year change of +0.64% ranking it in the 12th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in St. Louis is -0.58% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.143% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a pace that can support growing businesses. The negative hours deviation suggests that even existing workers are seeing reduced hours, rather than an expansion of genuine demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 4.30%, ranking it in the 36th percentile. This indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication is that businesses may still face some competition for top talent, and wages may not be as depressed as in markets with much higher unemployment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in St. Louis is +0.64%, ranking it in the 12th percentile. This slow wage growth signals a relatively flat cost environment for employers, but it also means that workers have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but they may also struggle to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living score ranking it in the 31st percentile, with a PSF of $167/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.95/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.52. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it less attractive for talent without wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising +1.2% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability challenge.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +0.39% year-over-year, ranking it in the 66th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. However, the relatively slow growth rate means that hiring capacity may still be limited, especially for businesses with high labor demands.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in St. Louis is increasing by +9.19% year-over-year, ranking it in the 64th percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain talent, especially if they offer relocation assistance or other benefits.

Days on Market

The median days on market in St. Louis is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.7%, ranking it in the 80th percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market also suggests that the market may be normalizing, which could lead to more moderate price growth and reduced pressure on affordability.

Office Economy

St. Louis has an office economy score ranking it in the 16th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more attractive for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a relatively affordable and accessible market, with a moderate level of labor market slack and slow wage growth. However, the city's biggest risk or constraint is its low labor demand and limited talent pool, which may make it challenging for businesses to attract and retain top talent, especially in knowledge-economy sectors. Decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when considering St. Louis as a location for their business.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #38 OF 50

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

C+

POOR

39.1th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	10
Unemployment	20% weight	24
Wage Growth	15% weight	72
Cost of Living	12% weight	80
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	72
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	4
Days on Market	5% weight	64
Office Economy	3% weight	20

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-1.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-37.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	32 days	median, +10.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 39.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its above-average wage growth, with a 72nd percentile rank. The labor demand metrics, including a -1.45% employment growth rate and -0.971% weekly hours deviation, signal a contraction in the job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -1.45% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.971% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand contraction, indicating that the job market is shrinking. The low labor demand composite score of 2.27, ranking in the bottom tier, further reinforces this signal.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.30%, ranking in the 24th percentile, indicating a below-average but not extremely tight labor market. This means that while there is some slack in the market, hiring may still be moderately challenging. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate may lead to some wage pressure, but it is not as severe as in tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +5.30%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating above-average wage growth. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means good news for worker purchasing power. As wages rise, workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living score ranking in the 80th percentile, with a PSF of $220/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.37, resulting in a ratio of 5.89. This high percentile rank indicates that the city is more affordable relative to its peers, with a slightly decreasing PSF YoY. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of +0.78% year-over-year, ranking in the 72nd percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for hiring capacity. As the labor force grows, businesses will have access to a larger pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has decreased by -36.97% year-over-year, ranking in the 4th percentile. This sharp decline signals a tightening of the housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This could pose a risk to workforce accommodation and attraction.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is currently 32 days, with a +10.3% year-over-year increase. This increase in days on market, ranking in the 64th percentile, indicates a slightly slower market. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is becoming more accessible, with homes taking longer to sell.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a professional and office worker share ranking in the 20th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. However, it may not be the ideal location for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers a unique combination of above-average wage growth and affordability, making it an attractive location for businesses that can navigate its contracting job market. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future, posing a risk to workforce accommodation and attraction.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #39 OF 50

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

C

VERY POOR

35.6th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	40
Unemployment	20% weight	4
Wage Growth	15% weight	24
Cost of Living	12% weight	43
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	76
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	36
Days on Market	5% weight	68
Office Economy	3% weight	50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-12.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, +5.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.70, which is near the median. The city's current economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 5.30% and its below-average wage growth of +2.04%. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with some constraints on hiring and labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.43% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.239% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The negative employment growth rate indicates that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.30%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 4th percentile. This indicates a relatively loose labor market, with some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +2.04%, which is below average, ranking 24th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This could be beneficial for businesses looking to manage labor costs.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living percentile rank of 43, with a PSF of $177/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.18/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.76. This indicates that the city is near the median in terms of affordability, neither extremely expensive nor very affordable. This means that businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +0.92% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking 76th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a positive implication for hiring capacity, as businesses will have access to a growing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -12.03%, which is below average, ranking 36th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability concerns and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.4%. This indicates a relatively slow market, with homes taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this could also be a sign of a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 2.52, which is near the median, ranking 50th percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool, making it suitable for businesses that require specialized office workers, but not ideal for those seeking a highly concentrated knowledge economy.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a mixed economic environment, with some advantages in terms of labor costs and accessibility, but also constraints related to labor demand and housing affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability concerns and impact the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #40 OF 50

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C

VERY POOR

35.6th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	20
Unemployment	20% weight	28
Wage Growth	15% weight	32
Cost of Living	12% weight	22
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	54
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	70
Days on Market	5% weight	98
Office Economy	3% weight	8

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+15.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, +20.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.15, which is below average at the 20th percentile. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand and high cost of living, with employment growth at -0.82% year-over-year and a cost of living ratio of 6.17, driven by a PSF of $227/sqft versus $36.79/hr in wages. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.82% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.777% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the labor market experiencing a decline in both jobs and hours worked. As a result, businesses may face a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 4.20%, which is below average at the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With a tight labor market, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +2.83%, which is below average at the 32nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate of wage growth suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. As a result, workers in this city may experience modest increases in purchasing power, but employers may not face significant labor cost pressures.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living ratio of 6.17, with a PSF of $227/sqft versus $36.79/hr in wages, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The rising PSF, up 3.6% year-over-year, further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of -0.01% year-over-year, which is near the median at the 54th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is essentially stagnant, with little expansion or contraction. As a result, businesses may face a stable but limited hiring pool, with minimal growth in the available workforce.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is increasing by +15.03% year-over-year, which is above average at the 70th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future. As a result, businesses may benefit from a more stable and affordable housing market, making it easier to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +20.0%, ranking at the top tier at the 98th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for workers relocating to this city. However, this may also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 0.74, ranking at the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This suggests a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech, finance, or consulting. However, the city may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a relatively stable but limited labor market, with moderate wage growth and a high cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the weak labor demand, which may limit the city's ability to support business expansion or relocation. As a result, companies should carefully consider the labor market dynamics and potential challenges in attracting and retaining talent in this city.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #41 OF 50

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

C

VERY POOR

35.2th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	70
Unemployment	20% weight	34
Wage Growth	15% weight	16
Cost of Living	12% weight	12
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	30
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	20
Days on Market	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	24

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.6%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-21.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	38 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of average labor demand and below-average cost of living and labor force growth. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 5.29, which is above average at the 70th percentile, and its wage growth rate of +1.22%, which is in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with some job growth but limited upward pressure on wages.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.69% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.025% from its own 12-month baseline, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than typical, suggesting a growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.29 is above average, at the 70th percentile, further supporting this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.70%, which is below average, ranking at the 34th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. Companies looking to staff up in this city may face challenges finding available workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.22%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking at the 16th percentile. This slow wage growth suggests a relatively flat cost environment for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power may not be increasing significantly.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living score that ranks at the 12th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $344/sqft to $38.23/hr, or 9.00. Although the price per square foot is decreasing by 0.3% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is shrinking at a rate of -0.59% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the available workforce is not expanding.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has decreased by 21.43% year-over-year, signaling a tightening housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, potentially exacerbating the challenges of attracting and retaining talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 38 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which could make it tough for relocating workers to find housing. However, the lack of change in days on market suggests a stable, albeit competitive, environment.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom ranks at the 24th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers a mix of average labor demand and below-average cost of living and labor force growth, making it a challenging location for businesses seeking to expand or relocate. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited and shrinking labor force, which poses significant challenges for hiring and talent attraction, potentially outweighing any benefits from the city's current economic conditions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #42 OF 50

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

C

VERY POOR

33.8th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	28
Wage Growth	15% weight	44
Cost of Living	12% weight	76
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	4
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	84
Days on Market	5% weight	56
Office Economy	3% weight	30

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.1%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+3.5%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-3.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-2.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+36.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
29 days
median, +16.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 33.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score heavily influenced by its poor labor demand and labor force growth metrics, which are both at the 0th and 4th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 1.50, driven by a -3.19% employment growth rate and -1.154% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in the job market. This combination of negative employment growth and below-trend hours worked indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -3.19% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.154% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 1.50. This combination signals a contraction in the job market, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The negative employment growth and below-trend hours worked indicate a lack of labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 4.10%, ranking at the 28th percentile, indicating a below-average but not extremely tight labor market. This level of unemployment suggests that there is some slack in the market, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire, but still with some wage pressure. However, the relatively high unemployment rate compared to other metros may limit local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is +3.48%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing. The wage growth is not stagnant, but it is also not fast enough to significantly drive up labor costs.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score of 76th percentile, with a PSF of $310/sqft and average hourly earnings of $45.36/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.83. The city's cost of living is more affordable than many of its peers, with a PSF that is falling -3.7% year-over-year. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is contracting at a rate of -2.11% year-over-year, ranking at the 4th percentile. This negative growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and potentially limiting the city's ability to support business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing by +36.76% year-over-year, ranking at the 84th percentile. This significant increase in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 29 days, with a year-over-year increase of +16.0%, ranking at the 56th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a high concentration of tech, finance, or consulting talent.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate wage growth environment, but its poor labor demand and labor force growth metrics pose significant risks for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force supply, which may limit the city's ability to support business growth and expansion.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #43 OF 50

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

C

VERY POOR

33.6th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	26
Unemployment	20% weight	26
Wage Growth	15% weight	46
Cost of Living	12% weight	10
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	98
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	16
Days on Market	5% weight	4
Office Economy	3% weight	74

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-22.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	25 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 33.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.18. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with employment growth of -0.80% YoY and weekly hours deviation of -0.598% from its own trend, as well as its extremely high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.94. The cost of living is a major concern, with a percentile rank of 10th, indicating a very expensive city.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.80% YoY and weekly hours deviation of -0.598% signal a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and a decrease in working hours. This combination suggests that businesses may be reducing their workforce or cutting back on hours, rather than expanding. The labor demand composite score of 3.18, ranking 26th percentile, further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.90% is relatively low, ranking 26th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that it may be moderately challenging to find qualified candidates, and wage pressure may be present. However, the market is not extremely tight, and businesses may still be able to find suitable candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.59% is near the median, ranking 46th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing. While this is a positive sign for workers, it may also lead to increased labor costs for businesses.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living is extremely high, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.94, ranking 10th percentile, indicating a very expensive city. This means that the city is at a significant disadvantage in terms of talent attraction, as workers may require wage premiums to afford the high cost of living. The fact that PSF is rising 0.4% YoY relative to wages further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.87% YoY, ranking 98th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding labor force supply. This means that the city has a strong hiring capacity, with a large and growing pool of potential candidates. Businesses may find it easier to hire in this city due to the expanding labor force.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -22.81%, ranking 16th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This signals that the city's housing market may be tightening, leading to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing. This could make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city and for businesses to attract talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 25 days, with a YoY direction of +0.0%, ranking 4th percentile, indicating a very fast-paced market. This means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The market is highly competitive, and businesses may need to provide relocation assistance to help workers navigate the housing market.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, ranking 74th percentile, indicating a strong presence of office and professional workers. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a highly educated and growing labor force, but its extremely high cost of living and tight housing market pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's high cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #44 OF 50

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

C

VERY POOR

33.1th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	12
Unemployment	20% weight	50
Wage Growth	15% weight	0
Cost of Living	12% weight	14
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	84
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	58
Days on Market	5% weight	54
Office Economy	3% weight	48

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-1.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+3.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, +2.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 33.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its weak labor demand and stagnant wage growth, notably a -0.31% employment growth rate and -1.45% year-over-year wage growth. The city's labor market is characterized by a combination of low employment growth and negative wage growth, signaling a challenging environment for businesses. The labor demand composite score of 2.37, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, further emphasizes this point.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is -0.31% year-over-year, accompanied by a weekly hours deviation of +1.522% from its own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the increase in hours worked is likely a result of a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 2.37, ranking in the bottom tier, reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 4.30%, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither too tight nor too slack. For businesses trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may not be overly difficult, but it also may not be exceptionally easy, as the market is close to equilibrium.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is -1.45%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 0th percentile. This stagnant wage growth signals that labor costs for employers are not rising, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing. The negative wage growth may attract businesses looking for a flat cost environment, but it could also indicate weak bargaining power for workers.

Cost of Living

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a cost of living score ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, with a PSF of $231/sqft and an average hourly earnings of $32.37/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.14. The city is relatively expensive, as the PSF is only decreasing by -0.4% year-over-year. This means that attracting talent without offering wage premiums may be challenging, as the high cost of living could deter potential employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is growing at a rate of +1.25% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, which could facilitate hiring for businesses. The increasing labor force can help meet the demands of growing companies.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is increasing by +3.44% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This moderate growth in building permits indicates that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increase in permits suggests that developers are confident in the city's future, which could lead to a more stable and attractive environment for businesses and workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.9%, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is relatively balanced, neither extremely competitive nor exceptionally slow. For workers relocating to this city, the market is moderately accessible, but the rising days on market could indicate a normalization of the market.

Office Economy

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has an office economy ranking near the median at the 48th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a moderately deep talent pool. The city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional roles, but it may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized tech or finance talent.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a relatively stable and balanced labor market, with a growing labor force and expanding housing supply. However, the city's weak labor demand and stagnant wage growth pose significant risks, as they may indicate a challenging environment for businesses to attract and retain talent, making it essential for decision-makers to carefully consider these factors when evaluating this location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #45 OF 50

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

C

VERY POOR

33.1th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	56
Unemployment	20% weight	16
Wage Growth	15% weight	20
Cost of Living	12% weight	41
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	12
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	54
Days on Market	5% weight	20
Office Economy	3% weight	14

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-1.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	33 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 33.1th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.16. This city's economic character is most defined by its near median labor demand and bottom tier unemployment rate of 4.50%, indicating a mix of stagnant job growth and a relatively high number of unemployed individuals. The labor demand and unemployment metrics are the most telling, with employment growth at -0.10% YoY and weekly hours 0.766% below trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -0.10% YoY, and weekly hours are 0.766% below trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth, with hours worked also decreasing, suggesting a lack of genuine demand expansion. The labor market is not absorbing new workers at a rate that would indicate strong economic growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 4.50%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that while it may be easier to find workers, the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +1.64%, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. The implication for worker purchasing power is that wages are increasing, but not at a rate that would significantly boost consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score with a PSF of $215/sqft, which is decreasing at a rate of -0.9% YoY, and an earnings ratio of $39.84/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.40. With a percentile rank of 41, the city is near median in terms of affordability. This means that the city is neither particularly expensive nor affordable, and businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is shrinking at a rate of -1.13% YoY, indicating a contraction in labor supply. This implies that the hiring capacity for businesses may be limited, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. The city's labor force growth is in the bottom tier, ranking 12th percentile, which poses a structural headwind for hiring.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -1.17%, indicating a slight tightening of housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. The city's building permits growth is near median, ranking 54th percentile, but the negative growth rate is a concern.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 33 days, with a YoY change of +0.0%. This indicates a relatively slow market, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. For a worker relocating to this city, the housing market is not particularly competitive, making it more accessible to find a home.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 0.88, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This indicates that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. The city's office economy is more geared towards industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a mix of relatively low labor costs and a slow-growing labor market, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the shrinking labor force, which poses a significant challenge for hiring and talent attraction. The city's lack of genuine labor demand expansion and limited labor supply growth make it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions. Overall, the city's economic character is defined by its stagnant job growth and relatively high unemployment rate, making it a challenging location for businesses that rely on a strong and growing labor market.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #46 OF 50

Richmond

Richmond

C

VERY POOR

33.0th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	16
Unemployment	20% weight	58
Wage Growth	15% weight	28
Cost of Living	12% weight	26
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	42
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	14
Days on Market	5% weight	70
Office Economy	3% weight	30

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-24.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	38 days	median, +5.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 33rd out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its weak labor demand and stagnant wage growth, scoring 16th percentile in both employment growth and weekly hours deviation. The labor demand composite score of 2.65 and unemployment rate of 3.70% are key metrics that characterize this city's economic landscape. With a wage growth rate of 2.57%, Richmond's economy is marked by slow expansion and moderate labor market tightness.

Labor Demand

Richmond's employment growth rate is -0.48% year-over-year, while weekly hours are 0.982% above the city's own 12-month trend, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.65, ranking in the 16th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.70%, ranking in the 58th percentile, indicating a near-median level of labor market tightness. This rate suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, there is still some competition for talent, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when recruiting in this market.

Wage Growth

Richmond's year-over-year wage growth rate is 2.57%, ranking in the 28th percentile, indicating below-average wage growth. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may enjoy a relatively flat cost environment, but workers may have limited bargaining power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $233/sqft to $35.94/hr, ranking in the 26th percentile, Richmond is relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the cost of living is higher than in many other metros. The 2.2% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is shrinking at a rate of -0.33% year-over-year, ranking in the 42nd percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. As a result, businesses may need to invest more in recruitment and training to attract and retain workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Richmond has decreased by 24.31% year-over-year, ranking in the 14th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future. As a result, businesses may face challenges in attracting and retaining workers who are relocating to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Richmond is 38 days, with a 5.6% year-over-year increase, ranking in the 70th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For workers relocating to this city, this may be a positive sign, as it suggests a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

With an office economy percentile rank of 30th, Richmond has a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

The Richmond metro area offers businesses a relatively flat cost environment and a slow pace of wage growth, but it is also marked by weak labor demand, a shrinking labor force, and decreasing affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering locating in Richmond is the tightening housing supply and the potential for decreased affordability, which may impact their ability to attract and retain workers. Overall, businesses must carefully weigh these factors when deciding whether to locate in Richmond.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #47 OF 50

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

C-

CRITICAL

31.7th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	4
Wage Growth	15% weight	74
Cost of Living	12% weight	67
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	8
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	72
Days on Market	5% weight	72
Office Economy	3% weight	4

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-2.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+18.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	47 days	median, +6.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its struggling labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its above-average wage growth, with a 74th percentile rank and a 5.82% year-over-year increase. The labor demand and unemployment metrics are particularly noteworthy, with employment growth at -2.64% year-over-year and an unemployment rate of 5.20%.

Labor Demand

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an employment growth rate of -2.64% and a weekly hours deviation of -1.073% from its own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city experiencing a decline in both jobs and hours worked. The labor demand composite score of 1.50 is in the bottom tier, reflecting this challenging labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.20%, which is in the bottom tier with a 4th percentile rank. This indicates a relatively slack labor market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the practical implication is that the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.82%, ranking in the 74th percentile. This is a relatively fast pace of wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers. On the other hand, it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living percentile rank of 67th, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peers. The city's PSF is $311/sqft, with a -2.8% year-over-year change, and the ratio of PSF to hourly earnings is 7.45. This affordability advantage can be a talent attraction benefit for businesses, as they may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is shrinking at a rate of -1.39% year-over-year. This contraction in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find workers. The bottom tier rank of 8th percentile underscores the severity of this labor force decline.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has increased by 18.23% year-over-year, ranking in the 72nd percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation. As the housing market responds to demand, it may become easier for workers to find affordable housing, which can be a benefit for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 47 days, with a 6.8% year-over-year increase. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The above-average percentile rank of 72nd suggests that the market is normalizing, which can be beneficial for businesses that need to attract workers from other areas.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 0.68, ranking in the 4th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses that require a different type of workforce.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the struggling labor demand and shrinking labor force, which can make it challenging to find and hire workers. This labor market challenge may outweigh the benefits of the city's affordability and wage growth, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider their hiring strategies and talent attraction plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #48 OF 50

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

C-

CRITICAL

31.1th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	24
Unemployment	20% weight	22
Wage Growth	15% weight	70
Cost of Living	12% weight	35
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	14
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	28
Days on Market	5% weight	36
Office Economy	3% weight	0

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.2%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-15.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	54 days	median, +3.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 3.17, and its above-average wage growth of 5.20% year-over-year. The labor demand and wage growth metrics are crucial in understanding the city's current economic state, with the latter indicating rising labor costs and the former suggesting a lack of genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 0.23% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -1.448% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are below trend despite modest job growth. This scenario may indicate a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.10%, which is below average, ranking 22nd percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to wage pressure. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.20%, which is above average, ranking 70th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also increases worker purchasing power. Businesses should factor in these rising costs when considering relocation or expansion in this city.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score ranking 35th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $337/sqft to $35.00/hr, or 9.63. Although the city's PSF is falling -2.3% year-over-year, the overall affordability is still below average. This means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums to offset the relatively high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -1.10% year-over-year, ranking 14th percentile. This decline in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent in this city.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has decreased by -15.03% year-over-year, ranking 28th percentile. This decline in permits signals a tightening housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.9%, ranking 36th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend may also signal a normalization of the market rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a professional and office worker share ranking 0th percentile, indicating a shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies, and is less suitable for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a mix of rising labor costs and a relatively tight labor market, with above-average wage growth being a key characteristic. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's declining labor force supply, which poses a significant challenge for hiring and talent recruitment, and may outweigh any potential benefits of locating in this city.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #49 OF 50

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

C-

CRITICAL

29.8th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	8
Unemployment	20% weight	46
Wage Growth	15% weight	34
Cost of Living	12% weight	49
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	18
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	44
Days on Market	5% weight	22
Office Economy	3% weight	10

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-1.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-6.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	38 days	median, -2.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 29.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand composite score of 2.26, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its labor force growth rate of -0.94% YoY, also in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -1.16% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.416%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as hours are above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This scenario suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers to fill new positions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 4.40%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced market with some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without excessive wage pressure. However, this also means that local consumer demand may be weaker than in areas with tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is +3.00%, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other metros. Workers in the area will see some increase in purchasing power, but it may not be enough to drive significant economic growth.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living score ranking near the median at the 49th percentile, with a PSF of $180/sqft and average hourly earnings of $31.79/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.66. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate without having to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is shrinking at a rate of -0.94% YoY, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find skilled workers to fill new positions.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County is decreasing at a rate of -6.07% YoY, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Louisville-Jefferson County is 38 days, with a YoY decrease of -2.6%, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales means that workers relocating to the area may face a competitive housing market, making it challenging to find affordable housing options.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Louisville-Jefferson County is 0.86, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors, making it less suited for these types of companies.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate pace of wage growth, but it is constrained by a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the challenging labor market, which may make it difficult to find and retain skilled workers, ultimately affecting business growth and expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #50 OF 50

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

D

EMERGENCY

22.6th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	6
Unemployment	20% weight	2
Wage Growth	15% weight	42
Cost of Living	12% weight	51
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	52
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	6
Days on Market	5% weight	32
Office Economy	3% weight	28

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-34.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	58 days	median, +1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of D, ranking 22.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and high unemployment rate, at 4.70%. The labor demand composite score of 1.88, combining a -0.77% employment growth rate and a +1.341% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in the job market. These metrics indicate a challenging economic environment for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Jacksonville is -0.77% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating 1.341% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 1.88 falls in the bottom tier, at the 6th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.70%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with significant slack, making it easier for businesses to staff but also suggesting weaker local consumer demand. Businesses trying to hire in this market may face less competition for talent, but may also need to consider the potential impact of a weaker local economy.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Jacksonville is +3.46%, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace, while worker purchasing power is also increasing. This balance may be beneficial for businesses looking to attract and retain talent without excessive cost pressure.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living ratio of $218/sqft to $37.21/hr, with a -2.2% year-over-year change in PSF, ranking near the median at the 51st percentile. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of -0.05% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This slight contraction in the labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. However, the impact is relatively minor, and businesses may still be able to attract workers from other areas.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Jacksonville is -34.14%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the city. This could have significant implications for businesses looking to attract talent from other areas.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Jacksonville is 58 days, with a +1.8% year-over-year increase. This indicates a slightly slower market, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile. For workers relocating to the city, this may make it easier to find a home, but businesses should still be aware of the potential for a competitive housing market in the future.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Jacksonville is 1.84, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, or consulting. However, the city may still be attractive for businesses in other industries, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The city of Jacksonville presents a challenging economic environment for businesses, with weak labor demand and high unemployment rates. However, the relatively affordable cost of living and moderate wage growth may still make it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult to attract talent from other areas.